Newsletter Collaborative Platform for Epidemic Modelling and Data Analytics

April 2025

News and updates

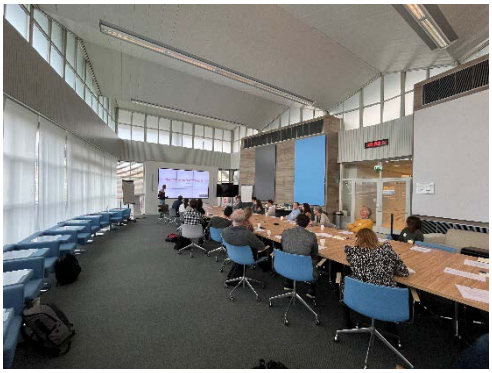
Funding news

In 2024, we drafted and submitted a proposal to the Ministry of Health. There is encouraging news regarding funding for 2025. We have recently been notified that funding will be available until December 2025 to continue the development of the Platform. Our proposal and request for structural funding, from 2026 onwards, is still under consideration.

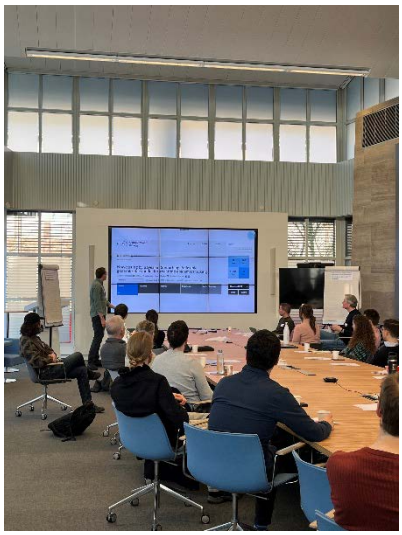
Events recap

The Future of Nowcasting Infectious Diseases: an international meeting

On Thursday and Friday, February 13th and 14th, 2025, the Collaborative Platform for Epidemic Modelling and Data Analytics hosted an event titled "The Future of Nowcasting Infectious Diseases" at the RIVM.



Nowcasting of infectious diseases involves predicting the current and past number of cases by symptom onset date in real-time using incomplete or delayed reporting. Although nowcasting techniques for infectious diseases have existed for years and were frequently used during the COVID-19 pandemic, they remain underutilized in infectious disease surveillance. There is potential to improve these methods further and to improve communication with end users.



The event brought together 25 international researchers from institutions such as the Karlsruhe Institute of Technology, LSHTM, ETH Zurich, Hasselt University, Stockholm University, and the Robert Koch Institute, all of whom are actively involved in or interested in nowcasting infectious diseases. This international event was co-organized with Johannes Bracher (KIT, Germany) who is a key international contributor to nowcasting efforts.

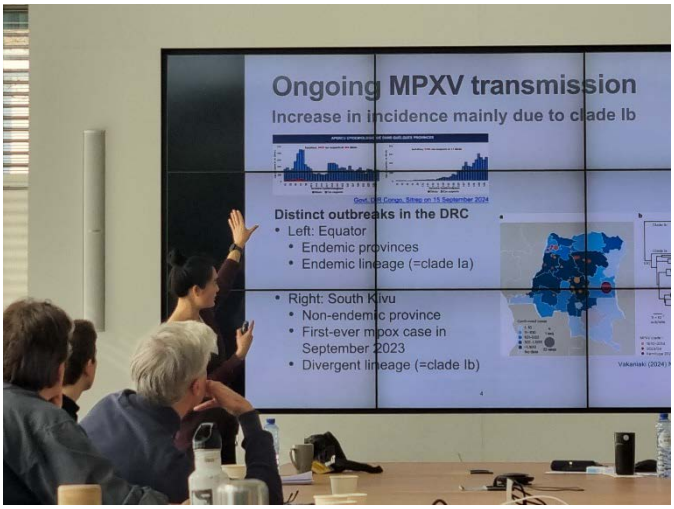
Through a series of presentations, breakout sessions, and plenary discussions, participants shared the latest practices and explored new methodologies. The key takeaway was participants identified existing challenges, such as disrupted reporting patterns during holidays. These insights gave participants a clear direction for their research.

The two half-day meeting concluded with discussions on further possibilities in nowcasting. The involved researchers in the Netherlands will take a more active role in the international nowcasting community.

Meeting on Mpox, HIV, and STI Modelling

On the 3rd of March 2025, the Collaborative Platform for Epidemic Modelling and Data Analytics hosted an event entitled "Meeting on Mpox, HIV, and STI Modelling" at the RIVM.

The event brought together about 30 researchers involved in or interested in modelling of mpox, HIV, and other STIs. The participants were from various institutions across the Netherlands, including GGD Amsterdam, GGD Rotterdam-Rijnmond, Amsterdam UMC, Utrecht UMC, Erasmus UMC, Maastricht University, Groningen University, Soa Aids Nederland, Stichting HIV Monitoring, as well as Sciensano from Belgium.



During the meeting, researchers presented findings from their modelling work, shared experiences and solutions to issues relating to the lack of data, computational limitations, and the translation of modelling findings to practice. Modelling studies were presented investigating the impact of a potential HIV cure, as well as the impact of testing and of PrEP on HIV transmission. New modelling efforts were discussed about the transmission of mpox clade Ib and the role of the pharynx in onward transmission of gonorrhoea. Research was also presented about the effect of condom preferences on chlamydia transmission and about the cost-effectiveness of HPV vaccination for women reaching the screening age. Most of the models presented were compartmental and agent-based models, but also economic models and back calculation models were discussed.

One aspect that was underlying most of the presentations was the importance of human behaviour and perceptions - such as beliefs about infection risk, severity of an STI, and the effectiveness of screening or vaccination – on both the dynamics of STI transmission and the effectiveness of public health interventions.

This highlights the value of including these factors in STI models and the need for data to inform model parameters describing these factors. A key takeaway message is that, despite decades of knowledge about STI prevention and the availability of effective treatment, accurate tests, and vaccination for some infections, considerable public health efforts are still needed to reduce the total disease burden and public health expenditures on STIs. These public health efforts require the researchers involved in STI modelling to work in close collaboration with partners, such as Soa Aids Nederland, Stichting HIV Monitoring, and municipal health services.

Upcoming meetings and events

- June 23 – 27, 2025 2nd ESPIDAM, the European Summer Program in Infectious Disease Analysis and Modelling, organized by Stockholm University, Sweden
- September 2025, 5th meeting on the collaborative platform. Attendance by personal invitation only
- Fall 2025: Workshop with TNO on the ZonMw project "Phaeton"—Enhancing pandemic preparedness through a collaborative, privacy-by-design data modeling environment

LinkedIn

We encourage you to stay connected by joining the LinkedIn group: Epidemic Modelling and Data Analytics. Many of you are already members, but if you know colleagues who might benefit from joining the group, feel free to invite them! Share their names with us at collabforepidemodatanalytics@rivm.nl, so the administrators, Valérie Eijrond and Jacco Wallinga, will grant them access to the group.

Share Your Events and Updates with Us!

If you know of a relevant seminar, course, meeting, or if you would like to organize an event together with the platform, feel free to let us know by emailing us at collabforepidemodatanalytics@rivm.nl . Additionally, if you have any updates, events, or news related to Epidemic or Infectious Disease Modelling and Data Analytics for our next newsletter, don't hesitate to reach out at the same email address.

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